Chenchus are expert archers and trackers and even kill tigers with poisoned arrows at times.' They dwell in 'small beehive-shaped huts with mud walls and roofs covered with palm leaves and reeds'. Panthers often came down the hills to prey on livestock; occasionally, even a tiger showed up from the Kurnool forests nearby. In the ten months that Longhurst spent in the valley over four years, he 'shot six panthers to the great delight of the local villagers, and the Chenchus in particular, who actually ate the flesh of these animals'.[2]

We know nothing of Venkataramayya's dealings with the locals. What became well known was his sighting of a finely inscribed stone pillar in the jungle. He couldn't read the Prakrit inscriptions in Brahmi script but he took rubbings. Word spread to the press and officials of the British government. But it wasn't until 1926 that experts came to investigate, such as Rangaswami Saraswati, an epigraphist, and Hamid Quraishi, an ASI archaeologist and a deputy of Longhurst.



*Figure 1. Pillar carving showing exercising wrestlers*

It was soon clear that the schoolteacher had reported one of the greatest archaeological finds in south India—the extensive remains of an ancient city rich in magnificent sculptures and monuments, including the only